

In-water cleaning removes biofouling from submerged surfaces of vessels or other structures. It includes hull grooming, propeller cleaning or polishing and cleaning of niche areas.

Release of biofouling and toxicants can spread invasive aquatic species and pathogens. This impacts the aquatic environment, water quality and human health.

The Australian anti-fouling and in-water cleaning guidelines (exposure draft)

The Australian anti-fouling and in-water cleaning guidelines offer best-practice guidance on:

- application, maintenance, removal and disposal of anti-fouling coatings
- cleaning of biofouling on vessels and movable structures in Australia.

The guidelines also contain the in-water cleaning standards. These standards give regulators a voluntary decision-making framework. This helps them assess the biosecurity and chemical contamination risks of in-water cleaning in Australian territorial seas.

Exposure draft

An exposure draft of the guidelines is now available while we continue to consult with relevant regulators on a voluntary decision-making framework to support their assessment of in-water cleaning risks.

The legislative framework of in-water cleaning is location specific. It is a shared responsibility between relevant government agencies and port authorities. They decide whether service providers are allowed to operate in their area.

The Department of Climate Change, Energy, the Environment and Water (DCCEEW) has commenced a four-month public comment period to gather feedback on the exposure draft. The submission form is available on the [Water Quality website](#) and should be submitted via email to waterquality@dcceew.gov.au.

The deadline for submissions is 1 March 2025.

Download

[Exposure draft: Australian anti-fouling and in-water cleaning guidelines \(PDF 911 KB\)](#) [Exposure draft: Australian anti-fouling and in-water cleaning guidelines \(DOCX 2.3 MB\)](#)

If you have difficulty accessing these files, visit [web accessibility](#) for assistance.

Requests to in-water clean in Australia

The approval process to conduct in-water cleaning or treatment in Australian waters is complex. The application process varies between locations and can involve many government agencies and port authorities. They will consider the biosecurity and toxicant risks and impacts the activity may have on the environment.

Contact authorities for permission to clean your vessel in state or territory waters. It is important you give authorities enough time to consider your request before your proposed cleaning activity.

State and territory contacts

Contact the relevant state or territory authority for advice on cleaning your vessel:

New South Wales

Department of Primary Industries

Email [Aquatic Biosecurity](#)

Port Authority of NSW

Email [Shipping Manager](#)

Northern Territory

Department of Primary Industry and Fisheries

Email [Aquatic Biosecurity](#)

Queensland

Department of Agriculture and Fisheries

Email [Biosecurity Queensland](#)

Phone 13 25 23

Email [Department of Environment and Heritage Protection](#)

Phone 13 74 68

Also contact the Port Authority, harbour master or Maritime Safety Queensland. This depends on location of proposed clean.

South Australia

Primary Industries and Regions SA

Website [Biofouling and Ballast Water](#)

Email [Biosecurity](#)

Phone (08) 8429 0823

Email [Environment Protection Authority SA](#)

Phone (08) 8204 2004 or 1800 623 445

Department of Environment and Water SA

Phone: (+61 8) 8204 1910

Tasmania

Biosecurity Tasmania - Department of Natural Resources and Environment Tasmania

Email [Biosecurity TAS](#) or [Invasive Species](#)

Phone (03) 6169 9021 or (03) 6165 3777

TasPorts

Email [Reception](#)

1300 366 742

EPA Tasmania

Incident Response Officer

Email [Incident Response](#)

Phone 1800 005 171

Victoria

Department of Energy, Environment and Climate Action

Email [Marine Pests](#)

Western Australia

Department of Primary Industries and Regional Development (DPIRD) – Aquatic Pest Biosecurity Group

Vessel Management enquiries

Email [Vessel Management](#)

General Aquatic Pest Biosecurity enquiries

Email [Aquatic Biosecurity](#)

Phone (08) 9203 0111

DPIRD only assess the pest biosecurity risk. Contact the relevant harbour master/port authority for cleaning in declared port areas.

Contact other relevant authorities for advice on contaminant release or discharges.

Great Barrier Reef Marine Park

For all in-water cleaning related activities contact:

Great Barrier Reef Marine Park Authority

Email [Assessments and Permissions](#)

Source: <https://www.agriculture.gov.au/biosecurity-trade/aircraft-vessels-military/vessels/marine-pest-biosecurity/biofouling/inwater-cleaning-australia>